The First Conversation

Launch Pad founding cohort, 2027-2028 - guide-facing working copy

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The First Conversation - Launch Pad founding cohort (2027-2028)

Status: v0.1 working draft, authored 2026-09-24 from the 8-voice fleet meeting (Jake Sisko, Naomi Wildman, Pavel Chekov, Kira Nerys, Ibn Khaldun, Comes, Accord, Cura). Written now; **first use after the pilot morning has been watched**; revised from the first real family conversation. **Companions:** `2026-06-24-launch-pad-three-year-story-cycle-v0.1.md` (the spine), `2027-2028-launch-pad-studio-year-plan-v0.3.md` (the operating plan), `launch-pad-STATUS-AND-HANDOFF.md` §5-6 (the one-page Family note and the access statement this composes with). **Minutes:** `evoke-agents-backup/agents/meetings/2026/09/2026-09-24-launch-pad-first-cohort-conversation-questionnaire.md`

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0. What this is, and is not

This is the conversation a family and the Launch Pad have before either says yes. It is **not an interview, an audition, or a test.** It has three honest jobs, and only three:

1. Does the family understand what this is and what it is not?
2. Is the learner's yes their own?
3. Can the guide honestly hold this learner, within the limits the access statement states?

It produces no score, no rank, no grade. If more than seven learners fit, that is a real problem and it is handled in §7, by a stated method, never by ranking people.

Sequencing. Nothing here runs before three things exist: the one-page Family note (what this is / is not, how you leave, how removal works), the **access statement** (what one guide with an infant can hold and cannot provide), and these fit signs, published to families in plain language. A conversation held before the access statement exists becomes invisible screening. That is the whole Ring-3 finding, and it binds.

Not before the pilot. The one real Origin morning (2-4 teens, the 100 Dreams, Salus and Jake in the room) is where the fleet learns whether the guide can meet a no. Use this after that morning has been watched.

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1. Before the conversation - what the family receives

Sent with the invitation, in plain language (aim for eighth grade), translated or with an interpreter offered when the household's first language is not English:

- **The one-page Family note.** What the Launch Pad is (a three-year studio, pen and paper, one guide, a small room) and is not (not therapy, not accredited, not a school with grades). How you leave. How removal works and who can appeal it. The six refusals, as a promise the family can hold us to.
- **The access statement.** Honestly: one guide, an infant worn on guide days, no aide, no speech or occupational therapy, self-managed Monday and Wednesday mornings. What the room can hold. What it cannot. Who we would warmly point you toward if we cannot.
- **The fit signs (§2)**, so "fit" is never a private judgment.
- **The mode menu (§3.1)**, so the family chooses how the conversation happens.
- **This sentence, verbatim:** *"Pass is always allowed. Any question you don't want to answer, you skip, and nothing is owed."*

1.1 Language (Kira's ruling, 2026-10-13)

A household's first language is an access question, not a fit question. It is never read against the fit signs and never enters the guide's notes.

- **The programme provides and pays for an interpreter** at the family conversation and at the learner's own yes, in any language the household asks for. A family is free to bring their own instead, and that costs nothing and means nothing.
- **The learner never interprets their own admission conversation.** Not for a parent, not for a sibling, not "just for this part."
- **No family member is pressed into interpreting either.** If a relative offers and the family wants that, fine. Nobody is asked.
- **The reason, on the record:** a sixteen-year-old translating *"is this what you want?"* to her own mother cannot answer it. The seventh promise says your no is real. Spoken through a child's own mouth, to the person they are answering about, it is not. Boise seats resettled families; this will arrive, not might.
- Written materials reach the family in their language, or an interpreter walks them through each one aloud before anything is signed. **No countersignature is taken on a document the signer could not read.** That binds the Family note and the Family Charter.

Recruitment posture (from Ring 3): **invitation, not persuasion.** Recruit on the design and the refusals. Show the room, not a child. No urgency, no scarcity. Promise the conditions, never the outcome.

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2. What we are looking for - eight fit signs, each yes/no, never ranked

Written as what it looks like and what it is not. The guide reads for these; the guide never scores them.

#	Sign	What it can look like	What it is NOT
1	**A live question, or a thing already in motion**	A dream said out loud; a problem that will not leave them alone; something they are already making, running, fixing, caring for	"Knows what they want." A settled answer at sixteen is data about where they are, not a strength. The devout learner's "I am here to be faithful, not to examine" is a valid answer to this sign
2	**Something done that nobody required**	A rabbit hole they went down; a skill they taught themselves; a job, a sibling, a kitchen, a garden they hold because someone had to	Enthusiasm performed for adults; a resume
3	**Can say no to an adult**	Disagrees with the guide in the room and survives it; says "I don't want to do that one" when offered a real out	Compliance; the fast yes; charm
4	**Can be witnessed and can witness**	Listens when someone else tells a story; can stand a little discomfort at being seen	Confidence; volume. The quiet witness counts fully

#	Sign	What it can look like	What it is NOT
5	**A relationship to rest**	Can name what they do when nothing is required; or honestly says "I can't stop," which the guide needs to know	Productivity; a full calendar as proof of seriousness
6	**A family that can hold the covenant**	Parents who hear "no progress channel, no guide on demand, no comparing children" and can say what that will cost them	A family that agrees fast
7	**Access needs the room can hold, or warmly refer**	"What helps you learn, what gets in the way," answered honestly and read against the access statement	"Fit." If the honest answer is "we cannot hold this," the family hears that and a real referral, in writing
8	**The learner's own yes**	Given a week later, alone, without a parent in the room, in any medium	The parent's yes in the child's voice, on the same afternoon

Signs 1-5 are the learner's. Signs 6-7 are the family's and the guide's. Sign 8 is the learner's alone, after.

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3. The learner conversation

Who is in the room: the learner, the guide, and a second adult (pilot default: Salus or Jake; see §8 for when the second adult leads). The second adult is not there to score. They are there to be able to say afterward, "you were managing that no, not meeting it."

Length: about 45 minutes. Shorter is fine. The learner ends it whenever they want.

Record: paper notes by the guide against §2 only. No recording. No transcript. The second adult reads the notes and countersigns them. The notes are shown to the family on request.

3.1 The mode menu (the family chooses; the learner can change their mind on the day)

- At a table, in the studio room, with tea and something to eat

- On a walk, outside
- With a parent in the room, or with a parent in the next room
- Written questions sent a week ahead; the learner answers in writing, drawing, voice memo, or brings them to talk through
- Spoken, written, drawn, signed, or with an interpreter

Bring one thing, if you like (never required): an object, a page you wrote, a drawing, a song, a photo, a thing you made. It gives you somewhere to start that isn't words.

No homework. Nothing is assigned before enrollment. "Bring one thing if you like" is an offer with a real pass, not a task.

3.2 The shape (mirrors a guide day, so the learner meets the actual thing)

Arrival. Sit, eat, no agenda for a few minutes. The guide says the pass sentence out loud: *"Pass is always allowed. Skip anything. Nothing is owed."*

The settle. Thirty seconds, feet on the floor, look around the room, one breath. The same settle that opens every guide day. Offered, not required.

The questions. Below. Pick from them; do not run them all. The guide holds questions, not answers.

A taste. Ten minutes of the real thing: one impossible question held Socratically ("Could one person change a system?" or one the learner brings), or one choice game from Session 3. The learner sees what a morning is like, and the guide sees whether the learner can say "I don't know" and whether they can disagree.

The out. Somewhere in the taste, the guide offers something the learner can decline right there: *"Here's a part of this you can say no to right now, and I'd like to see you do it if it isn't yours."* Sign 3 is read here, not in the answers.

Close. *"Anything you want to ask us? Anything you want to tell us that we didn't ask?"* Then: what happens next (§5), and the sentence *"you don't have to decide anything today."*

3.3 The questions

How to ask them. One question, then stop. Count to five before you say anything else. Do not stack examples onto a question: the examples are you answering it for them, and a sixteen-year-old hears that as the adult being nervous. Never run all of these; pick the ones the conversation opens. "I don't know" is a complete answer, and so is a shrug.

The pass sentence is said once, at the start, so it does not have to be repeated into every question.

Opening - What did your family tell you this is? - What do you think it is? - What do you want to ask me?

A live question (sign 1) - What can't you stop thinking about? - Do you know what you want to do with your life? - If yes: How did you land on that? - If no: Most people don't. This year is built for that. - What are you here to be faithful to? *(for the learner whose frame is faith, family, or duty)*

Something nobody made you do (sign 2) - What have you learned that nobody made you learn? - What's the last rabbit hole you went down? - What are you responsible for at home?

Saying no (sign 3) - When was an adult wrong and you knew it? - What did you do? - What did a teacher or a parent want from you that you didn't give? - *(Sign 3 is read live in the taste, not from these answers.)*

People, and being alone (sign 4) - When someone tells you something hard, what do you do? - Six or seven people, one room, three years. What's good about that? - What's hard about it? - When do you need to be alone? - What happens when you can't be?

Rest (sign 5) - What do you do when nothing is required of you? - Is stopping easy or hard for you? - Fridays here never get filled. What do you think of that?

The mornings you run - Mondays and Wednesdays, the morning is yours. What would you do with it? - What would make it go wrong?

How you work (sign 7, in the learner's own words) - What helps you learn? - What gets in the way? - How do you like to get your thoughts down? - What would make this room hard for you?

Close - What haven't I asked that you wish I had? - What would make you say no to this?

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4. The family conversation

Who: the parents or guardians, the guide, the second adult. About 30 minutes. The learner may sit in or not, their choice.

What we say, plainly: - What this is and is not (the Family note, again, out loud). - The access statement, out loud, with the honest sentence: *"One guide, an infant on guide days, no aide. Here is what I can hold. Here is what I can't. If I can't, I'll say so and point you somewhere real."* - The exit and removal: how you leave any time; that removal is a written, witnessed act with an appeal path that is not the guide. - The Table covenant, spoken never signed: **no progress channel, no**

guide on demand, no comparing children. Then the question: *"What would that cost you? Say it now, while it's cheap."* - The Log is the learner's. No one reads it. Not the guide. Not you. - The learner's yes comes later, alone. Yours does not stand in for it.

What we ask: - What do you hope this does for your kid? (Listen for outcome-promises we must not make.) - What worries you about it? - What does your family need from a place like this that we haven't named? - Is there anything about your kid's learning, body, or life that we should know so the room can actually hold them? (Read against the access statement. Answer honestly.) - What would make you pull them out?

What we do not ask for: transcripts, grades, test scores, diagnoses, essays, references, a photo, or the learner's interior.

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5. The learner's yes (a week later, alone)

About a week after the conversations, the learner is asked, on their own, without a parent present, by the second adult where §8 applies: *"Is this yours? You can say no, and nothing changes between us."*

Any medium: a text, a note, a drawing, a voice memo, a conversation. A "not yet" or a "no" is honored as fully as a yes and is never carried to the parent as a problem to fix.

No yes from the learner, no seat. The parent's yes does not stand in.

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6. The guide's notes and the reply

Notes: one page, paper, against §2. For each sign: yes / no / not seen, and one sentence of what was seen. **No numbers.** The second adult reads and countersigns. The notes are kept with the family record and shown on request; never used for anything else.

The reply, within two weeks, in writing, to every family: - *Yes:* the seat, the start date, the Family note to countersign, and the sentence "you can still say no." - *We can't hold this:* the honest reason in plain words, tied to the access statement, and a real referral (a named person or program, not "look elsewhere"). Written by the guide, read by Accord (or the second adult) before it is sent. It must pass the Exhale Test: a family can read it and breathe. - *Not this year (see §7):* the reason, a place on the list, and a real next door.

Rule (Naomi's): "not this year" is never "not you." A reply without a written reason and a warm next step is the crossing we are watching for.

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7. If more than seven fit

The eight signs are yes/no. They are never ranked. If more learners fit than the room can hold:

1. First, the honest number. The year plan's target is five to six; seven is the ceiling because the deep block splits at six with an infant worn. The guide names the real number for this year before choosing anyone.
2. The method is **stated to families before application opens**, so no one learns it after. Three the fleet put on the table, unresolved, captain's call:
    - **Lottery among those who fit.** The least class-marked. Any "reasoned choice" drifts toward the articulate family.
    - **Readiness to start.** The learner who is sixteen by the cutoff and has no other door this year, before the one who could wait a cycle and lose nothing.
    - **Reasoned choice with a written reason per family**, countersigned by the second adult.
3. Every family that fits and is not seated: a written reason, a place on the list in the order the method produced, and a real next door (the next cycle, the Adventure studio, another program).
4. **The list is the renewal channel, not a courtesy.** The mid-cycle joiner the design already welcomes comes from here.

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8. The founder's child, and her community's children

Any child of the founder, or of her close community, gets exactly the same conversation, with one change: **the second adult leads**, the guide is present but not leading, and the learner's yes (§5) is asked by the second adult in private. That learner needs a real way to say no to someone who is not the person they love.

Enrollment of the founder's own child is decided by the accountability node (pilot default: Salus and Jake) with the guide, never by this conversation alone and never by the guide alone. The clause routes into the Family Charter draft that goes to counsel.

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9. Before first use (binding)

- [ ] Access statement written, Chekov Tier-1 read, published to families
- [ ] Family note (one page) written and published
- [ ] These fit signs published to families, plain language, Kira read
- [ ] Interpreter arranged and funded for the family conversation and the learner's yes (§1.1), with the no-child-interpreter rule stated to whoever books it
- [ ] Plain-language pass at eighth grade on every family-facing piece, Kira's read
- [ ] Second adult named for the conversations
- [ ] Comes walks this document as a sixteen-year-old applicant and reports what the body says
- [ ] Accord reviews the "we can't hold this" and "not this year" letter templates
- [ ] Oversubscription method chosen by the captain and stated in the family materials
- [ ] The pilot morning has run and been watched (the first no, met or managed)

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10. Deliberately NOT in this instrument

No score. No rank. No numbered sequence of "levels." No test, essay, transcript, grades, references, or diagnosis. No recording or transcript of the conversation. No homework before enrollment. No question that harvests the learner's interior (family story, worst day, grief) - those belong to the formation, later, with the floor under them, not to the door. No urgency and no scarcity in any family-facing sentence. No "fit" as a stand-alone verdict.

Origin asks "who am I?" of a learner who does not yet know. The door must not demand the answer first.

"We evoke - we never extract."